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Courts at center of removal efforts

Trump administration turns system it oversees into ‘deportation factory’

By Caroline Kubzansky and Joe Mahr
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

On a May morning, Immigration Judge Peter Kim’s Loop courtroom offered a scene that would help explain how Chicago would soon lead the nation in deportation orders.

In notes kept by a volunteer group of court observers, they described an overflowing courtroom, with people standing two rows deep up to an interpreter’s desk. One observer jotted down: “I’ve never seen this before.”

Neither, apparently, had Kim, a recently transferred judge from Los Angeles. According to the notes, he said, “this is so hard. This is not going to work.”

It was the first recorded instance of dozens of so-called “mega-master” hearings: enlarged versions of early-stage hearings where immigrants appear in large groups. Combined with a massive turnover in judges on the Trump-controlled court and less-immigrant-friendly rules, the hearings helped fuel a dramatic rise in the number of removal orders issued by judges there — turning what once was a large but average court into a national trendsetter for the presi-

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INSIDE



EILEEN T. MESLAR/TRIBUNE

Plastic surgeon’s license suspended

Officials have temporarily barred Dr. Ayoub Sayeg from practicing medicine in Illinois following a Tribune investigation finding the state had not disciplined him despite eight patient deaths.
Chicagoland, Page A2

Houthis fire missiles at Saudi Arabia

Yemen’s Houthi rebels said they fired missiles and drones at Saudi Arabia in response to Saudi strikes on the Red Sea city of Hodeida.
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The Sky absent from WNBA All-Star party

Chicago throws a bash for WNBA All-Star weekend — but the hometown team is left watching from the sidelines.
Sports

END OF AN ERA

By Robert McCoppin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Patti Miller has never known a life without the horses at Hawthorne Race Course.

Her visits to the track in west suburban Stickney began when she was a baby. Her grandfather trained horses there. As a teenager, she worked at Hawthorne as a pony girl, riding alongside high-strung racehorses to guide them to the starting gate in front of thousands of fans.

Now 69, and after decades as a trainer herself, she’ll lead her horses out of Hawthorne for good, as the course ran what was likely its last race on July 19 after 135 years in operation. As the last remaining commercial course in the Chicago area, Hawthorne’s closure is the end of an era that once saw five tracks running the most popular spectator sport in the country.

The Carey family has owned the track for more than a century. Despite years of assurances from

owner Tim Carey that he would get financing to open a casino to save the track, that never happened. The facility went bankrupt and is being sold to a company that will end racing there.

“It’s crushing,” Miller said. “We hung tough, and it never happened. How did they screw this up so bad?”

The answer to that question lies in years of missteps by lawmakers and track owners, competition from an explosion of gambling, and people turning away from a sport that once dominated American culture.

In the mid-20th century, horse racing drew more spectators than even the national pastime of baseball. Throngs turned out to see legendary horses like Seabiscuit, Man o’ War and Secretariat, who were well-known even to non-racing fans.

But as sports like football and basketball grew, horse racing began to tail off in popularity, seen

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Horse racing was once the nation’s most popular sport. Hawthorne’s bankruptcy, impending closure mark its demise in Chicago area

Above: Horses run on grass during the last race of the day at Hawthorne Race Course on July 19 in suburban Stickney. The course likely ran its last race on July 19, after 135 years in operation. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Poor air quality an enduring problem for some

Residents put monitors in areas where pollutants are ever-present issue

By Finnegan Belleau
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Sonia Monet Saxon often wakes up around 4 a.m. to the smell of burning asphalt.

Her McKinley Park home is close enough to an asphalt plant that the stench makes it difficult to go outside some days.

Long before wildfire smoke from Canada and Minnesota brought record-breaking levels of PM2.5 to the Chicago region a week ago, pollutants have been an ever-present problem in many communities.

That’s why, a day before the smoke plumes descended, Saxon

was using zip ties to fasten an air quality sensor to the railing of a house in McKinley Park, the latest of 15 or so installations she’s done over the past few years. Her goal is to monitor pollution from the asphalt plant.

“I love this neighborhood so much, but if you were here yesterday or the day before around this time, it would smell like burning asphalt,” she said. “It was almost unbearable to be outside.”

Air quality in Chicago is measured in different ways, from fairly cheap sensors such as the one Saxon installed to the sensors in the network set up last summer by the city of Chicago and University of Illinois Chicago. Then there are the sophisticated regulatory monitors that are much more

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Sonia Monet Saxon, a community science organizer at Neighbors for Environmental Justice, installs an air quality monitor at a home in the McKinley Park neighborhood on July 15. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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